Personal Statement - Rapheal Prince Obodugo

I submit this statement as someone who has spent the last decade building at the edge of what financial infrastructure can do, first for others, then for the markets I came from, and now for the intersection of AI and the systems that govern how money moves. My career is not a single trajectory but a set of deliberate choices made across geographies: each role chosen to sharpen a different capability, each venture chosen to solve a problem the market had not yet formalised.

My foundation was built through discipline before it was built through opportunity. Admitted as the top candidate among over 700 applicants to a competitive secondary institution, I spent six years on scholarship developing the intellectual rigour that would later define how I approach engineering problems. By the time I entered university to study mechanical engineering, I had already taught myself software programming, drawn not to machinery but to systems that mirror human behaviour. That self-directed instinct has remained the constant across everything since.

My early professional work at PrepClassNG introduced me to the practical constraints of building for Nigerian users, infrastructure that must be reliable without the margin for error that engineers in other markets take for granted. From there, I moved through increasingly demanding international contexts: frontend and user experience engineering at Baobab Partners in New York, open-finance infrastructure at Rollee in Paris, the launch of a new product vertical at Ecosia in Berlin. Each environment tested a different dimension of what I knew. By 2021, when I was admitted to Toptal, the global network that accepts fewer than 3% of applicants, it was a confirmation of a standard I had already been holding myself to.

The appointment as a Founding Engineer at HitPay, a Y Combinator S21-backed payments infrastructure company in Singapore, represented the clearest articulation of that standard in practice. Payments companies do not afford founding engineers the luxury of adequate. I designed the design system that formed the foundation for the entire frontend engineering team, and I worked on reliability patterns in a context where a bug is not a

inconvenience but a financial incident. The rigour of that environment shaped how I subsequently approached building my own company.

MySub was built from an observation, not a pitch deck. West Africans had been pooling money informally, for rent, subscriptions, school fees, travel, over WhatsApp groups and spreadsheets for years. The behaviour existed; the infrastructure did not. I formalised it. Without a single dollar of external funding, MySub grew to 360,000 users across West Africa and the United States, generating $6.7K in monthly recurring revenue and achieving a strategic acquisition reported independently by Punch Nigeria and Business Insider Africa. The growth came entirely through community embedding and product quality, the only growth mechanism that survives without a marketing budget. MySub's selection for Unicorn Factory Lisboa's accelerator programme validated its international relevance beyond its home market.

Beyond commercial product work, I have contributed to the shared infrastructure that underpins global web development. My merged pull requests to three widely-used Node.js packages, ip-address (172 million downloads per month), express-slow-down (315,000 downloads per month), and express-useragent (99,000 weekly downloads, 309 dependents), address functional reliability concerns: memory leak prevention, API consistency, and type safety in bot detection. These are not peripheral packages. They are embedded in production systems at scale across the industry. I have also contributed to public discourse on technology's social implications: as a panelist at DevFest Enugu 2025 (1,300+ attendees, part of the global Google Developer Groups series) and, most significantly, as the AI Expert selected by CNBC Africa for a live studio broadcast on the future of work and skills across the continent, a panel that also included the Dean of Lagos Business School and the CEO of SeamlessHR. That selection was an editorial judgment by a major pan-African broadcaster that I was a credible authority at the level of established institutional figures.

My current work is Avae AI, an AI-powered continuous audit platform for modern finance. The institutional recognition it has already attracted, NVIDIA Inception Programme, Google for Startups Cloud Programme, and the MARL Studio Spring 2026 accelerator cohort, reflects the strength of both the problem and the team's credibility to solve it. The United Kingdom

is the right environment for the next stage of this company. London's concentration of AI research talent, fintech regulatory expertise, and access to European capital markets is not incidental to what Avae needs, it is constitutive of it.

I intend to establish Avae's primary operating base in the United Kingdom. Concretely: I will build the core engineering and product team in London, targeting ten high-skilled hires within three years. I will pursue research partnerships with UK universities working on AI interpretability and financial systems, areas directly relevant to what Avae is building. I will continue contributing to the open source ecosystem through the Nigerian and UK developer communities, and I intend to formalise the public education work I began at CNBC and DevFest through structured engagement with UK AI policy discussions and developer programmes.

My application satisfies the mandatory criteria through independent recognition by a pan-African broadcaster and two national publications as an authority in AI and technology, as well as admission to Toptal's top 3% engineer network, each an unsolicited external judgment of exceptional standing. My optional criteria submissions demonstrate contribution beyond commercial work through open source infrastructure used by hundreds of millions of monthly downloads (OC2), and substantial commercial and entrepreneurial impact through MySub's bootstrapped scale, acquisition, and the institutional validation of Avae AI (OC3). I come to the United Kingdom not to begin a career but to scale one.